The breadth of economics research

14.33 Research and Communication in Economics · Fall 2026

Economists study health, politics, history, discrimination, networks, and much more. The examples below illustrate how a personal interest can become a research topic. MIT economics professors work across these areas, including research using machine learning. Applications include bail decisions, predicting mortality to assess end-of-life spending, and measuring political polarization from speech. Econometricians also develop tools for causal inference with high-dimensional data.

Examples of economics research

- **Crime:** Pretrial detention increases guilty pleas and reduces employment, with no detectable effect on future crime. — Dobbie, Goldin, Yang
- **Development:** Longer life expectancy can increase investment in education. — Jayachandran, Lleras-Muney
- **Education:** Assistance with financial aid applications increases college enrollment among low-income students. — Bettinger, Long, Oreopoulos, Sanbonmatsu
- **Environment:** Changes in wind direction help identify the mortality costs of air pollution. — Deryugina, Heutel, Miller, Molitor, Reif
- **Finance:** Life insurers' exposure to mortality risk creates incentives to fund medical research. — Koijen, Van Nieuwerburgh
- **Gender:** Surgeon gender affects how referring physicians respond to patient outcomes. — Sarsons
- **Health:** Black men select more preventive services when matched with a Black doctor. — Alsan, Garrick, Graziani
- **History:** Trade models and ancient merchants' clay tablets help locate lost Assyrian cities. — Barjamovic, Chaney, Coşar, Hortaçsu
- **Industrial organization:** Utilities pass most emissions-permit costs through to electricity prices. — Fabra, Reguant
- **International trade:** The 2018 trade war reduced aggregate U.S. real income. — Fajgelbaum, Goldberg, Kennedy, Khandelwal
- **Labor:** Discrimination can become a self-fulfilling prophecy by reducing worker performance. — Glover, Pallais, Pariente
- **Macro:** Recessions are amplified when workers most exposed to job loss also cut spending most as income falls. — Patterson
- **Networks:** Aggregate relationship data can reveal network structure without listing every connection. — Breza, Chandrasekhar, McCormick, Pan
- **Political economy:** The Voting Rights Act shifted public spending toward counties with larger Black populations. — Cascio, Washington
- **Public finance:** State corporate tax cuts benefit firms, landowners, and workers. — Suárez Serrato, Zidar
- **Race:** Rising returns to skills help explain why racial earnings gaps persist despite educational convergence. — Bayer, Charles
- **Real estate:** Rent control reduces displacement of covered tenants but reduces rental supply and raises market rents. — Diamond, McQuade, Qian
- **Theory:** Strategic information disclosure can influence another person's decisions. — Kamenica, Gentzkow

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